governance regimes and rendered new mechanisms through which the Burmese military–state was able to increase its hold of contested territory.

The Kachin leaders interviewed all bemoaned having little to show for the seventeen-year accord, apart from being sidelined, discriminated against, and subject to rights abuses. The resumption of violence highlighted the incomplete nature of the ceasefire, which did not lead to renegotiation of the deep-seated ideological question of how sociopolitical power would be distributed to address systemic discrimination and disparity. They argued that Kachin participation in the flawed National Convention process and commitment to working within the system failed to produce an opportunity for genuine political dialogue. This would make the military government's denial of KIO registration to compete in the 2010 elections the real trigger for the resumption of violence in 2011. The regime's ultimatum — contravening previous assurances — that the Kachin troops must become border guards under partial control of the Tatmadaw prior to participation in the 2010 election, and thus prior to political dialogue, was central. From a Kachin perspective, this ultimatum invalidated the ceasefire and delegitimized armed non-state actors prior to the elections, diminishing KIO/A ability to negotiate for self-determination in any political dialogue, making a return to conflict almost inevitable.

CONCLUSION

Reframing 'ethnicity' in the Kachin conflict from a category of social analysis to a form of social relationships, or a dynamic set of historical narratives around how power is framed and contested in relation to processes of identification, leads us to conclude that the fundamental issues in the Kachin conflict are not resources, territory, or even discrimination based on cultural and religious difference. Rather, the key issues of the conflict are the politicized manifestations of competing ideological beliefs about the framing, distribution, and management of political power. Thus while personal vested economic interests have emerged, complicating pathways to peace, control of territory and resources remains both instrumental and symbolic: instrumental to providing the space and resources for communal survival and expression of identity, and symbolic in creating international legitimacy in the global political context of established state-sovereignty norms, as well as strengthening that nationalistic sense of identity.